

Chapter 105-1

A-Shuang.

Qin Lishuang.

Liang Shi had heard this name from Liang Xinzhou before.

Liang Xinzhou had asked her if she still remembered Qin Lishuang, and she had voluntarily confessed about losing part of her memories.

The dream and reality connected. The original host had been tied there, unable to move, letting Qin Lishuang paint her. She was a genius artist, but also a madwoman.

She would stop at nothing in pursuit of what she called the ultimate artistic sense. She even specifically tortured the original host to achieve the brokenness and desolation she wanted.

The original host was also a madwoman, but in front of Qiu Zimin, she became an obedient person.

"Taming a beast" was probably like this.

The beast could bare its fangs anywhere, but had to bow its head before its master.

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"Liang Shi." A familiar voice came through, like someone extending a hand to pull her out of the deep sea. But this boundless darkness still seemed like it wanted to swallow her whole.

She couldn't open her eyes and couldn't distinguish whose voice it was. She only knew to walk toward where there was light.

But where was the light?

There was no light anywhere.

Everything around was pitch black—she couldn't see her hand in front of her face. All around were cacophonous sounds.

She couldn't hear anyone speaking.

The wind howled. In the distance, light appeared. Faint lights danced across the sky—they were beautiful fireflies.

The sky now had a moon and scattered stars.

Though the light was faint, there was now a direction.

She heard someone calling: "Jiejie, jiejie."

She heard someone asking: "Jiejie, will you remember me in the future?"

"Jiejie, can we really escape?"

"Jiejie, don't cry. I won't cry anymore either."

"....."

This voice was very familiar, making her instinctively want to grab onto something.

But slowly, even this voice disappeared, replaced by cacophony.

There were too many different voices, too many people speaking. She had no idea whose voice she should listen to.

She also didn't know where she was.

The light ahead disappeared. Her surroundings turned back into a boundless deep sea, and the cold seawater was about to engulf her.

Even her last bit of consciousness was scattering.

"Liang Shi!" That cool voice carried tension, instantly pulling her scattered consciousness back together.

Then there was a dazzling white before her eyes.

Liang Shi finally opened her eyes. What met her sight was bright light. Xu Qingzhu was crouching in front of her, her expression anxious.

The other players were all standing not far away, watching her nervously.

Behind Xu Qingzhu was a group of people who looked like the escape room staff, also frightened and on edge.

Immersive escape rooms primarily catered to young players seeking thrills. People with heart disease, coronary heart disease, or other conditions that could cause stress-related reactions weren't suited to play this kind of thing, and the store wouldn't let them in. Before entering, they had all signed agreements confirming they didn't have these types of conditions.

But no one expected that Liang Shi would faint during a solo task. The staff were scared out of their wits.

Including the NPCs from the solo dungeon just now—the red-dressed lady whose wig Liang Shi had pulled off, and the NPC in fluorescent white who had grabbed Liang Shi's foot while lying on the ground—they were all standing in a row, looking worried, afraid something might have happened to Liang Shi.

They had already called 120¹, but then Liang Shi woke up.

Seeing that she had woken up, everyone breathed a sigh of relief.

After scanning the people present, Liang Shi looked toward Xu Qingzhu and instinctively smiled at her.

It was just a slight tug at the corners of her mouth. Her overall state wasn't good.

But Xu Qingzhu suddenly hugged her and said in a low voice: "You scared me to death."

Liang Shi was caught off guard by the hug. After a moment, she hugged her back and gently patted her back. "It's okay now."

Footnotes:

¹ 120: The emergency medical services number in China, equivalent to 911 in the United States or 999 in the United Kingdom.

Chapter 105-2

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This escape room experience was full of twists and turns.

It was only after they left that Liang Shi learned Xu Qingzhu had single-handedly solved the sixth stage that even many escape room exploration bloggers hadn't been able to crack—and she had used the champion solution.

The first solution was indeed collaborative. After finding the communication tool, people in the two spaces would exchange clues and solve it together.

The second solution was for a single person to unlock a new dungeon, essentially trading three side quests for the clues in Liang Shi's dungeon. It was rather tedious.

But there was also a champion solution—skipping the steps of the original logic and directly bypassing those three side quests to obtain the clues, which could rescue the teammate trapped in the dungeon task.

Xu Qingzhu had used the champion solution, and she was even ten minutes faster than a famous escape room exploration blogger who had been there before—someone the entire internet called the "Puzzle-Solving Boss."

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When Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were about to leave, the escape room shop owner not only apologized to Liang Shi but also asked Xu Qingzhu if she was interested in taking on a job to design new dungeons for their shop. The price was negotiable.

Xu Qingzhu politely declined.

Liang Shi also hadn't expected that she would faint during a solo task while playing an escape room. It was a bit embarrassing.

As they came out, she was still complaining to Xu Qingzhu: "Dream Castle isn't dreamy at all. They should call it Nightmare Castle instead."

Actually, what she had experienced in the escape room had made her feel quite unwell.

The distressing part was that she had no idea what to do.

Those chaotic memories had invaded her mind all at once—several scattered threads. No matter which one she pulled out, it was upsetting.

But she didn't want Xu Qingzhu to feel upset with her, nor did she want to spread her low mood, so she tried her best to act like she didn't care.

She even became more talkative than usual to cover up her low spirits.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't give her the chance to be talkative.

It was already evening when they came out of the escape room. Time had flown by while they were clearing stages—six or seven hours had passed without them realizing it.

Dusk had settled in. The streetlights on both sides of the road lit up. It was already late autumn, and only a few stubborn yellow leaves remained on the trees along the sides, swaying precariously on the nearly bare branches.

Xu Qingzhu had been very quiet since leaving the escape room. Liang Shi had tried to tease her a few times, and she had given her face by smiling, but the smile didn't reach her eyes. She still maintained her cool and distant demeanor.

It was as if they had gone back to when they first met.

No, it was like when Liang Shi had just transmigrated here—Xu Qingzhu had looked at her with particular coldness.

But there was a subtle difference from back then. Xu Qingzhu's body still subconsciously moved closer to her.

When the autumn wind blew over, Xu Qingzhu would walk beside her, staying very close.

But once the gust passed, Xu Qingzhu would put some distance between them again.

They hadn't walked very far—just from the escape room shop to the mall diagonally across the street. Since the distance was short, driving around would have taken longer than walking.

During this very short journey, Liang Shi's mind was churning with countless thoughts.

Just as they were about to reach the mall entrance, Liang Shi suddenly reached out and grabbed Xu Qingzhu's wrist. Her slightly cool fingernail pads gently rubbed against her wrist.

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up slightly, her gaze cool. "What is it?"

"What should we eat?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I don't know."

Her tone in answering the question was also very cold.

But Liang Shi didn't know where she had upset her.

Liang Shi wasn't feeling good. When those memories had hit her, it was like being thrown back into those same scenes and experiencing them all over again. The things she had been afraid of before, she was still afraid of now. Even if she was mentally comforting herself, the body had its own memory.

She was just deliberately suppressing it, unwilling to let that emotion show.

Yet she didn't know what was going on with Xu Qingzhu.

Ever since Liang Shi had woken up there and Xu Qingzhu had hugged her in lingering fear, Xu Qingzhu had been very cold.

Chapter 105-3

When leaving that shop, Xu Qingzhu's attitude toward the staff was even colder—it could even be called icy.

Liang Shi was silent for a moment but still asked: "Are you angry?"

"No," Xu Qingzhu said.

"Really?" Liang Shi pressed her lips together and said in a low voice: "But you don't look like you're not angry right now."

The atmosphere suddenly fell silent.

All around them were people coming and going. Occasionally, passersby would glance at the two of them but would just brush past.

The two stood not far from the mall entrance, eyes meeting.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu softened her voice and said: "I am angry."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi had no experience dealing with this kind of thing and didn't know what Xu Qingzhu was angry about.

She simply couldn't stand that cold atmosphere—it was so awkward—so she had taken the initiative to ask.

But after asking, then what?

She didn't know either.

So silence spread again. But the area around the mall was very noisy, with pedestrians constantly walking by. The road nearby was bustling with traffic—the sound of tires rolling over the ground. There was even an advertisement playing on loop at the top of the mall.

The advertisement featured Yang Shuyan's face, endorsing a skincare set.

Yang Shuyan's face displayed there was a powerful advertisement in itself.

The noise from the outside world made the silence between the two of them seem deathly still. Neither of them spoke.

Liang Shi felt an inexplicable nervousness. Her fingertips subconsciously rubbed against Xu Qingzhu's wrist, round and round.

It wasn't until Yang Shuyan's advertisement finished playing on the LED screen above the mall, changing to a popular star's music video.

As the restless intro music started, Xu Qingzhu finally spoke: "Why didn't you ask me what I'm angry about?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's thoughts were in disarray. At this moment, she could only follow Xu Qingzhu's lead.

"Then what are you angry about?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu broke free from her hand, looking even angrier.

Liang Shi was somewhat dazed, suddenly becoming inarticulate.

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, and after a silence, asked her: "Do you have some task you have to complete?"

Liang Shi: "?"

In that instant, her pupils contracted. She was about to deny it when Xu Qingzhu said: "From initially not divorcing me, to wanting to come to the escape room with me—what exactly is driving you to do these things?"

Liang Shi froze.

But Xu Qingzhu's voice became even calmer: "This is your business. If you don't want to say, I won't ask. But you..."

Her voice choked up here, and tears glistened in her eyes, particularly dazzling under the refraction of the cold sunlight.

Liang Shi's heart suddenly ached terribly.

It was like biting into an unripe hawthorn berry—both sour and astringent.

Especially when, after her choked pause, Xu Qingzhu looked into her eyes and said: "Can you please be nicer to yourself?"

It was like this before, and it's still like this now.

Always thinking about how others are doing.

Clearly scared to death, yet still pushing forward.

Clearly feeling very low, yet forcing herself to tell bad jokes.

"Do you know your bad jokes aren't funny?" Now that she had opened up, Xu Qingzhu's words poured out like floodwaters through a broken dam. "The smile you force looks awful—just like the perfunctory smile I gave you earlier."

"Seeing you smile like that is like you seeing me smile like that." Xu Qingzhu's voice was cool, yet carried a somewhat low, hoarse quality.

When she spoke, it wasn't accusatory, but every word fell into Liang Shi's ears like cool spring water on a summer day, flowing through her limbs and body, leaving her completely at a loss.

Not knowing what to do.

Wanting so much to respond, yet not knowing how to respond.

Wanting to say something to her, wanting to instinctively deny it, yet unable to speak.

So afraid that saying anything would make Xu Qingzhu even angrier.

Making Xu Qingzhu angry didn't even seem like the scariest thing. What was scary was that Xu Qingzhu would feel sad, would be hurt.

Those beautiful eyes would shed tears.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together and raised her hand. Her slender arm wanted to reach over and wipe away the tears that were about to form in Xu Qingzhu's eyes, but Xu Qingzhu took half a step back, leaving her arm suspended in midair.

Only a few centimeters from Xu Qingzhu's face, yet it seemed so far away—too far to touch.

Xu Qingzhu exhaled lightly, readjusted her voice, and said to her coldly: "I'm not asking you to tell me anything, and I'm not asking you to do anything for me. Just be yourself properly, okay? Liang Shi."

When Xu Qingzhu's cool voice called out the two characters "Liang Shi," her voice fell with an indescribable tenderness.

Just like this morning in bed, when the drizzling rain was falling outside and there was only faint light inside the room.

Xu Qingzhu had called by her ear: "Teacher Liang."

When she called out faster, it became "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi's fingers curled and then uncurled.

The two people standing in place looked as beautiful as if they were shooting a pictorial. A withered yellow leaf from a nearby tree fell onto Liang Shi's shoulder, the branches now completely bare.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at it, took her hand out of her coat pocket, and quickly brushed the fallen leaf off her clothes.

Seeing that Liang Shi still had no reaction, her emotions became hard to contain, so she turned and walked forward.

Chapter 105-4

Xu Qingzhu was very angry.

She was angry at herself for not solving the puzzles faster, for not finding Liang Shi sooner.

She was also angry at herself for agreeing to come play the escape room with her. Even more, she was angry at herself because she had known before playing that it was a five-star horror dungeon, yet she had still mischievously wanted to see Liang Shi embarrassed and scared, so she had gone to play this dungeon without Liang Shi knowing.

She was also angry that Liang Shi never learned to be good to herself, always putting others' needs and feelings first, forgetting that she herself was the one who needed love the most.

Since she was little, Liang Shi had always said she wanted to have lots and lots of love.

But even now, she only knew how to love others.

She was quiet, selfless, gentle, and tolerant—like warm mountain spring water, nourishing everything it flowed past.

Yet she alone forgot to love herself.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a teal wool coat, dark blue jeans, and a pair of polished black knee-high boots with five-centimeter heels on her feet, making her look tall and slender.

But in the autumn wind, her fine, soft hair was blown about, and the hem of her coat was lifted too. Her whole person seemed desolate and lonely.

After heaving a heavy sigh, she turned and walked toward the mall entrance.

In Liang Shi's eyes, it was a feeling of being frustrated with someone who wouldn't live up to expectations—so she didn't want to say more.

Liang Shi's hand dropped to hang at her side, Xu Qingzhu's words echoing repeatedly in her mind.

—I'm not asking you to tell me anything, and I'm not asking you to do anything for me. Just be yourself properly.

"Just be yourself properly."

How difficult those five characters were.

All along, people had only ever told her: you need to work hard and move forward, you need to establish some kind of persona, you need to become an actress that others love, you need to play roles that audiences like, you need to show your best side.

Almost everyone demanded that she be perfect, demanded that she be someone others liked.

Yet this was the first time someone had said—just be yourself properly.

What would probably follow was—I'll love you.

Liang Shi's heart was filled with something unknown, softening into a complete mess.

After Xu Qingzhu had walked a few steps, when that sentence had echoed in her mind for the third time, Liang Shi suddenly curved her lips into a smile.

She lifted her feet and jogged over, catching up to Xu Qingzhu in just a few steps.

Her hand grabbed Xu Qingzhu's forearm. Xu Qingzhu turned her head, her eyes still red.

Liang Shi opened her arms and hugged her tightly.

On the busy street with people coming and going, the streetlights cast a dim, golden glow.

Liang Shi buried her head in Xu Qingzhu's neck, her voice low and hoarse: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu's hands curled a few times in her pockets. In the end, she still didn't reach out, only humming a note: "Mm?"

"Don't be angry," Liang Shi said. "I was really upset just now."

Xu Qingzhu's chin rested on her shoulder. She could feel her hair and could smell the fresh orange scent in this world full of earthly warmth—it was the same shampoo she used.

Liang Shi said: "If you asked me to coax you right now, I would be unhappy and would think you were being unreasonable."

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but reach out and pinch her waist, letting out a soft hum: "I am pretty unreasonable to begin with."

"How could that be?" Liang Shi laughed softly. It was the first genuine laugh since leaving that shop—she laughed so hard her body trembled, and Xu Qingzhu trembled along with her. "Our Teacher Xu is the most understanding person in the world."

"Oh, stop." Xu Qingzhu pushed her, but Liang Shi held onto her and said: "I'm very upset today, so is it okay if I don't coax you?"

Liang Shi said: "If you're really angry, can I coax you tomorrow instead?"

Xu Qingzhu's hand that had been pinching her waist paused, then settled at her waist. "Then I'll coax you."

Chapter 105-5

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When Xu Qingzhu said she would coax Liang Shi, she took her upstairs to eat at a famous devilishly spicy hotpot restaurant.

Liang Shi couldn't really handle spicy food. When they entered the restaurant, she teased: "Is this coaxing me or coaxing yourself?"

"Coaxing you, of course," Xu Qingzhu said shamelessly.

They followed the server inside. Every table had a bright red soup base. No one came here to eat any other flavor, and many people's lips had turned a vivid red from the spiciness.

But when they reached their seats and the server handed them the menu, Xu Qingzhu said: "I want a dual-flavor soup base."

Before the server could say they didn't have dual-flavor soup bases, Xu Qingzhu continued: "One mushroom broth, one tomato."

Server: "?"

"I'm sorry, miss. We only have three flavors here: numbing spicy, extra spicy, and super spicy. If you want a dual-flavor, you can only pair it with a plain water base." The server patiently explained.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, her eyes clear, and said in a very polite tone: "But my wife can't eat spicy food. I want her to have these two flavors. Can you bring me two plain water bases and I'll cook it myself? I'll pay the full price."

The server was put in a difficult position—this was probably the first time she'd heard such a request.

However, it wasn't too difficult to accommodate. The server placed an order for two plain water bases and didn't charge her for them.

Xu Qingzhu ordered some dishes. After the server left, Liang Shi asked her in confusion: "Why come to a place that specializes in spicy food but not eat spicy, and make other requests instead?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't explain, only saying: "Wait for me five minutes."

Then she got up and left, walking past table after table of bright red hotpots.

Five minutes later, Xu Qingzhu returned with an instant mushroom soup base packet and tomato hotpot seasoning. She tore open the packaging and poured both packets into the pot.

Their table immediately stood out as completely out of place.

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu lowered her eyes, stirring the soup base with serving chopsticks. While waiting for the water to boil, she said to her: "You don't have to do certain things just because you're in a certain setting. Sometimes you can learn to break the rules."

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very soft.

Liang Shi looked at her through the misty steam. The hotpot restaurant was filled with spicy aromas, but only their table gave off the scent of mushroom soup and tomato—one milky white, one scarlet red. Everything was different from the surroundings.

Then Xu Qingzhu's voice sounded again: "People should be selfish. No matter how great you are, you shouldn't override human nature. Also, breaking rules and removing restraints feels really liberating. This is something I learned after dying once."

Liang Shi: "....."

She suddenly felt like the meal before her wasn't hotpot, but a pot of philosophy.

These two packets of hotpot seasoning had ascended to a higher plane right then and there.

Liang Shi put the plate of meat into the mushroom soup pot. "Others eat red while we eat white—that's actually pretty nice."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, then took the plate of meat from her hands and used the serving chopsticks to add it to the pot. "Don't move, I'll do it."

Liang Shi: "....."

For some reason, the scene from this morning suddenly appeared in her mind.

It was the same words, but it wasn't Xu Qingzhu who had said them.

At that time, it was Liang Shi who had said: "Don't move, I'll do it."

Xu Qingzhu also only realized after saying it that these words seemed a bit off, but she didn't try to fix it, letting Liang Shi's imagination run wild.

Liang Shi thought about it so much on her own that her ears turned red. The sensation on her hands seemed to still linger.

She pinched her earlobe, and then Xu Qingzhu's arm reached across the table to also pinch her earlobe.

Liang Shi looked at her. "What are you doing?"

Xu Qingzhu's slightly cool fingertips still carried some moisture. Hearing her question, she asked with a light laugh: "Teacher Liang, your ears are so red. What are you thinking about?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Her teasing tone made Liang Shi's ears turn even redder, and they were continuously reddening under her fingertips.

Her rubbing motion kept reminding Liang Shi of this morning's events, so Liang Shi pressed down on her hand. "Eat meat."

"Whose meat?" Xu Qingzhu replied without thinking.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi gritted her teeth secretly. "Yours."

Xu Qingzhu sat across from her, using the serving chopsticks to pick up a slice of meat for her. Through the misty steam, she smiled at her: "Which part?"

Liang Shi: "....."

This meal was really hard to get into her mouth.

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When they came out of the mall, it had started raining again outside.

It was as if the brief clear weather that afternoon had only been to let people go out for a walk. The pattering rain had dampened the entire city.

Quite a few people were trapped in the mall because they hadn't brought umbrellas.

Many people stood at the mall exit waiting for the rain to stop. There were young couples nearby hugging each other because it was too cold. Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi at most stood a bit closer together, each with their hands in their own pockets, as if they didn't know each other.

Liang Shi glanced several times at the young couples around them, then looked at the unmoved Xu Qingzhu. She didn't dare make any moves either.

Then someone nearby jostled them, pushing Xu Qingzhu directly toward Liang Shi. Liang Shi reached out to steady her.

The person apologized profusely. Xu Qingzhu replied distantly that it was fine.

Liang Shi steadied her and asked: "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu straightened up but said: "Something's wrong."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu put her hand into Liang Shi's coat pocket. "My pocket is a bit cold."

A moment later, Liang Shi also put her hand back into her coat pocket, which happened to cover Xu Qingzhu's hand. Indeed, as she said, her coat pocket was too cold, so even her hand was cold.

Liang Shi smiled and said: "My pocket is warm."

"Are all Alphas this warm, or is it just you?" Xu Qingzhu asked casually.

Liang Shi shook her head. "I don't know. I've never held an Alpha's hand."

"So you've held an Omega's then?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "Do you count?"

"I count," Xu Qingzhu said definitively.

Neither of them spoke loudly—only loud enough for each other to hear. It was just the tone of casual chitchat.

The awkward argument from that afternoon seemed like it had never happened.

When the rain was about to stop, Liang Shi's phone rang. It was another unknown number.

After taking over the original host's phone that had no contacts saved, Liang Shi had gotten used to answering unknown numbers. She picked up and greeted politely: "Hello?"

All she heard from the other end was crying—a female voice.

The voice sounded somewhat familiar. After careful recognition, Liang Shi tentatively called out: "Wanwan?"

Liang Wanwan suddenly stopped, and between sobs, responded with an "mm."

Liang Shi immediately said: "What's wrong? Don't cry first. What happened?"

There was a pause on Liang Wanwan's end before she said: "Jie, I... I slapped Liang Xinran."